

"I remember watching Krishanu Dey in the early 1980s when he won the Federation Cup, the Durand Cup, and the IFA Shield with Mohun Bagan. I've been in love with the club ever since," he added.

As the noise from the home fans petered out after the leveller, a band stood up to play *Bella Ciao!* and kept going until most of the home supporters began clapping along to the rhythm.

The Italian folk song, once a partisan anthem against oppression, had become a symbol of solidarity during the pandemic. And that very solidarity unified a nervous crowd, rallying them behind their team.

Minutes later, Brison, the local hero, struck again. The final score: 2-1.

In Christianity, the Magi were the men who brought gifts to the newborn Christ. They are said to have given the first Christmas presents. On December 20, Goa received its own gift, wrapped in love from its people and a brace from a boy the state had nurtured with care.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee

Inner walls crumble

Only ten minutes of regulation time remained in the game between Chennaiyin and Bengaluru. The Blues were leading 3-2, but Chennaiyin had equalised twice during the match, and the home fans were feeling bullish about a third.

Towards the Diary's right side, Bengaluru's Ryan Williams delivered a lackadaisical cross into the opposition box. Assuming that Chennaiyin defender Laldinliana Renthlei had a textbook clearance under control, the Diary shifted his focus to the scattered words on his laptop screen.

Suddenly, the vociferous crowd fell silent, drawing the Diary's attention back to the pitch. There, he saw Renthlei stooped over with his head in his hands, the ball nestled in the back of the net.

Confused, the handful of journalists in the press box turned their eyes to the big screen, which replayed the moment when Renthlei had sheepishly bundled the ball into



his own goal, handing the derby victory to the visiting team.

With each passing minute until full-time, the home support depleted in noise and number as Chennaiyin succumbed to yet another defeat.

Joan Mathew Jacob

Captain courageous

All sports demand something heroic from the person wearing the captain's armband — whether it involves providing leadership on the field or doing something intrepid to inspire teammates to deliver a superlative performance — akin to a general in war. This must have been the thinking that prompted Mohun Bagan Super Giant skipper Subhasish Bose to ignore multiple fractures on his left cheekbone and choose action over rest.

Doctors had advised the dependable left-back to undergo reconstructive surgery after a blow from FC Goa defender Sandesh Jhingan's elbow during a goalmouth tackle. Scans later revealed three fractures in the left cheekbone region.

Fully aware that his presence was vital for his side, which was aiming to regain its winning momentum following the defeat against FC Goa, Bose chose to sacrifice personal concerns and offer his services to the team.

"Given Mohun Bagan's status in the ISL, we cannot afford to suffer successive losses and relinquish our position as the leader (in the current league standings). That was why I chose to play, despite the doctors

Costly mistake: Sunil Chhetri (centre) of Bengaluru FC celebrates an own goal by Chennaiyin's Laldinliana Renthlei. FSDL

advising surgery, which would have kept me out of action for at least two months," Bose said after leading his side to a spectacular comeback win against Punjab FC (at Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium).

Bose (**below**) was seen wearing a protective mask in the first half, which he removed after the break as it was hindering his vision. "The team doctors are attending to the injury very well, and I am hopeful of recovering with the prescribed medication. I cannot ignore the emotions of our fans during this crucial stage of the tournament," said Mohun Bagan's captain courageous as he looked ahead to the team's next match at home against Hyderabad FC.

Amitabha Das Sharma

